

M6T2: Conflict Resolution for Couples — 11 min

Video File M6T2-Conflict.mp4 (conflict-resolution flowchart) · **Resources** Conflict Guide.pdf (flowchart, "I" statements, timeout rules, repair scripts, journal page) · **Xp** 100 total · Resolve 1 Issue 50 · Journal Outcome 30 · Share Anonymously 20

Target runtime 11 min · 1,314 spoken words · ≈ 8.8 min at 150 wpm · ≈ 9.7 min at a warm 135 wpm

0:00–0:30 **HOOK**

[VISUAL: Cynthia on camera.]

If this course has started an argument in your house, I'd like to take some responsibility. One of you watched the sugar training and cleared the pantry; the other came home to find their chocolate gone. One of you wants to do the detox; the other thinks it's paranoid. That's not a sign something's wrong with you. It's what happens when two people change at different speeds. Today is about arguing well, and there is a science to it.

0:30–4:30 **THE COMMON CONFLICTS AND WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS**

[VISUAL: Slide: "The health-habit fights: pace · policing · money · 'you don't care as much.'"]

Let me name the fights I hear most on this journey. Pace: one partner is all in, the other is easing in, and "easing in" reads as "not trying." Policing: one partner comments on the other's plate, and the other feels surveilled in their own kitchen.

Money: organic strawberries, filters, supplements, and whose priorities win. Coping: one wants to talk about the negative test for an hour, the other wants to go for a run, and each thinks the other is doing it wrong. And underneath all of them, the sentence nobody says out loud: "You don't want this as much as I do."

[VISUAL: Slide: "Gottman: the four horsemen — criticism · contempt · defensiveness · stonewalling."]

John Gottman spent decades watching couples argue in his lab and could predict, with startling accuracy, which marriages would last. What predicted trouble wasn't fighting; happy couples fight. It was four specific behaviors he called the four horsemen. Criticism: attacking character instead of naming a behavior; "you're so lazy about this" instead of "the dishes are still there." Contempt: eye-rolling, mockery, sarcasm; the single strongest predictor of divorce in his data. Defensiveness: meeting every complaint with a counter-complaint. And stonewalling: shutting down, going silent, leaving the room. If you recognized yourself in one of those, welcome; everyone does.

[VISUAL: Slide: "Flooding: above about 100 beats per minute, nobody can listen."]

Gottman also found something physiological that changed how I coach couples. When an argument escalates, heart rate rises, and above roughly a hundred beats a minute a person is flooded: the thinking brain goes offline, and every word from that point is damage. This is why "let's just talk it through" at eleven p.m. so rarely works. Nobody can talk it through when they're flooded. They can only take a break, calm down, and come back. His research found that couples who took a structured break of at least twenty minutes and returned to the conversation did far better than couples who pushed on.

And one number worth keeping: in Gottman's observations, the couples who thrived had about five positive interactions for every negative one during conflict. Five to one. A touch, a joke, a "you're right about that," a "thank you for saying it." That ratio is where Module Four's gratitude practice pays its rent.

Each horseman has an antidote, and the Conflict Guide lists them side by side. For criticism, the gentle start-up we're about to practice. For contempt, building a culture of appreciation, which is Module Four's gratitude practice doing double duty. For defensiveness, taking responsibility for even

a small part: "You're right that I didn't ask." And for stonewalling, the structured timeout, so that withdrawing becomes a pause with a return time rather than a wall. You don't need to eliminate the horsemen; nobody does. You need to notice them and reach for the antidote, and noticing is most of it.

4:30–8:30 TOOLS

[VISUAL: Conflict-resolution flowchart: Soft start → "I" statement → Listen (loop from T1) → Flooded? → Timeout 20 min → Return → Repair → Agreement → Gratitude.]

Tool one: the soft start-up, which you met in Module One. Gottman found that the first three minutes of an argument predict how it ends. Start with your own feeling and a specific situation, not with their character.

Tool two: "I" statements, from the psychologist Thomas Gordon. The shape is: "I feel" plus the feeling, "when" plus the specific behavior, "because" plus what it means to you, and "I'd like" plus a request. "I feel scared when the sweets come back into the house, because I'm working so hard on my cravings, and I'd like us to keep them somewhere I don't see them." Compare that to "You're sabotaging me." Same situation. Completely different evening.

Tool three: the timeout. When either of you notices flooding, a racing heart, a raised voice, the urge to walk out, say the agreed word. Some couples use "pause." Some use "twenty minutes." Then physically separate, do something calming, not rehearsing your next point, the breathing from Module Four is ideal, and come back at the agreed time. The return is non-negotiable; a timeout without a return is stonewalling with a nicer name.

Tool four: repair attempts. These are the small gestures that de-escalate: "Can we start over?" "I'm sorry, that came out harsh." "I'm on your side here." A hand on the arm. Gottman found that whether repair attempts were offered and accepted mattered more than how bad the fight was. So make them, and, harder, accept them when they're offered, even mid-fury.

Tool five: the agreement. End with one specific, small thing you'll each do. "Sweets go in the garage cupboard." "I'll ask before I comment on your plate." "We each get one dinner a week that's fully our choice." Write it in the Conflict Guide. Then, and this is the Module Four tie-in, close with one gratitude each, for something the other did in the

conversation. "Thank you for taking the timeout." It sounds small. It's the five-to-one ratio, applied.

Two more things the research adds. First, timing: Gottman found that couples who raised issues within a day or two, gently, did better than couples who stored them up for a big reckoning; a stored grievance grows contempt in the dark. So the Conflict Guide asks you to bring things small and early. Second, accepting influence: in his data, the men who were willing to be influenced by their partners, to say "that's a fair point, let's do it your way," were in far more stable relationships than those who dug in. That applies in both directions, and on this journey it applies to the plan itself: a plan that both of you have shaped is a plan both of you will keep.

8:30–10:00 **EXAMPLES**

[DEMO: Cynthia walks through one fight, start to finish, playing both parts.]

Let me run one fight through the flowchart. The pace fight. Partner one has been all-in for six weeks; partner two hasn't watched a video since Module Two.

Soft start and "I" statement: "I feel alone in this when I'm the only one watching the trainings, because I'd started to imagine us doing it together, and I'd like to know what's actually going on for you." Listen, using the loop: "It feels like homework, and every time I open it I feel behind, and then I feel guilty, so I avoid it." Reflect: "So it's not that you don't care. Opening it makes you feel behind, and the guilt makes you avoid it." "Yes." Now, flooding check: both calm. Repair: "I'm sorry I read it as not caring." Agreement: "What if we watch one training a week together, on Sunday, and I stop counting the ones you haven't watched?" "I can do one a week." Gratitude: "Thank you for telling me the guilt part." "Thank you for not making it a lecture."

That conversation took six minutes and ended with a plan. The original version of that fight, the one with "you don't care as much as I do" in it, could have taken all evening and ended with nothing.

I've sat with couples, in my work and in my own kitchen, whose resolve for this journey grew stronger after a well-handled fight, not because the fight was pleasant, but because

they learned they could survive one. That's a discovery every couple heading toward parenthood needs to make early.

10:00–11:00 HEART-LED CLOSE AND ACTION HANDOFF

[VISUAL: End card: "Conflict Guide PDF → Resolve 1 issue (50 XP) → Journal the outcome (30 XP) → Share anonymously (20 XP)."]

This is for your future family, and one day you'll show a child what it looks like when two people disagree and stay kind. You're practicing that now. Download the Conflict Guide, resolve one real issue using the flowchart for fifty XP, journal how it went for thirty, and share the outcome anonymously in the forum for twenty. Next, Training Three: the family you're picturing, written down together.

ACTION CALLOUT

RESOURCE Conflict Guide.pdf (four horsemen and their antidotes, flowchart, "I" statement builder, timeout rules, repair phrases, agreement and gratitude page, journal). **ACTION 1:** Resolve one real issue using the guide (50 XP). **ACTION 2:** Journal the outcome (30 XP). **ACTION 3:** Share the outcome anonymously in the forum (20 XP). **NEXT STEP:** Training 3 · Shared Visioning for Conception.